

The failure of the left



A perennial concern for left-wing political philosophers from the Frankfurt School onwards has been the continued success of capitalism, despite Marx's prediction of its inevitable collapse. After the failure of Soviet socialism in the Eastern Bloc, few states continued to follow any form of Marxist socialism or communism – even China developed its own version of a mixed economy. Marxist thinkers found themselves in opposition, and powerless. This was seen by Slavoj Žižek as providing something of an easy way out, however, since it allowed them to adopt a stance of resistance, theorizing about an ideal state without the responsibility of

putting it into practice, and ignoring Marx's own exhortation for philosophers to stop interpreting the world and start changing it. The real failure of the left, Žižek says, is to have given up on overthrowing capitalism and opted to continue talking about the elusive society it could have created. Instead, there should be a re-evaluation of revolutionary socialism in the light of what happened, and exploitation of capitalism's increasing failures.